Hackers Hit Supermarket Fridges Across Europe, Spoiling Food

From: CBC World Mined: 2026-11-03 5 min read

A hacking attack spread across Europe on Monday, hitting supermarket fridges and freezers from Sweden to Belgium and forcing stores to throw away spoiled food.

The attack raised temperatures in refrigerator and freezer units at dozens of stores. It hit supermarket groups Ahold Delhaize and Colruyt in Belgium and Luxembourg, as well as Swedish grocers ICA and Coop. Furniture-to-meatballs retailer Ikea also saw at least one store affected.

At an ICA **franchise** store in Stockholm, sales manager Engla Ingwall said the attack occurred at 2 a.m. but was only noticed hours later. "Everything is destroyed," she told Reuters during a visit to the store. "There has been a **cyberattack** and all our freezers reached 50 degrees [Celsius]."

A spokesperson for privately held ICA said the company was aware that a limited number of stores were affected by an incident overnight that impacted their refrigeration and freezer systems.

The incidents echoed an attack in France last month, when police said hackers seized control of cooling units at hundreds of supermarkets, causing fires and food losses. Ahold Delhaize also reported a cybersecurity incident to police last month.

No one has claimed responsibility for either attack. The incidents have heightened concerns among European authorities about **hybrid** threats to **infrastructure** amid growing security tensions since Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine. Moscow has repeatedly denied involvement in sabotage or **hybrid** warfare operations. Reuters could not establish who was behind Monday's attacks or whether they were linked to the incidents in France.

"It is not known who is behind this attack, and it may never be determined," said Katrien Eggers, spokesperson for Belgium's Centre for Cybersecurity. She said she was concerned about the growing number of incidents, in part due to artificial intelligence. "All IT systems are potentially **vulnerable**, and AI can now be used to successfully exploit these weaknesses - especially by **sophisticated** actors," she said.

Word Treasure

cyberattack -- An attack by hackers who break into computer systems to cause damage.

franchise -- A store owned by one person or company but run under a bigger company's name and rules.

infrastructure -- The basic systems a country needs to work, such as food stores, power, and roads.

vulnerable -- Easy to hurt or attack because of a weakness.

sophisticated -- Clever and advanced, often in a complicated way.

hybrid -- Made of different kinds of things mixed together, here different kinds of attacks.

Background you need

A cyberattack happens when hackers break into computer systems to damage them or take control of them.

Many supermarket fridges and freezers are now connected to computers, so their temperatures can be watched and changed from far away.

Cold food must stay cold to stay safe to eat, so when a fridge warms up, the food inside can spoil and must be thrown away.

Authorities worry about attacks on important systems like food stores because problems there can affect many people at once.

Break it down

LEAD: A hacking attack hit supermarket fridges and freezers across Europe on Monday, spoiling food.

KEY EVENT: Temperatures rose in refrigerator and freezer units at dozens of stores.

+- WHO: Supermarket groups Ahold Delhaize and Colruyt, Swedish grocers ICA and Coop, and at least one Ikea store.

+- WHEN: Monday, with the Stockholm attack at 2 a.m. and noticed hours later.

EVIDENCE: Engla Ingwall said all the freezers at her Stockholm ICA store reached 50 degrees Celsius.

OPEN QUESTION: No one has claimed responsibility, and it is not known who was behind the attack or whether it was linked to France.

Why it matters

Food stores depend on computer-controlled cold storage, so an attack on fridges can waste food across many countries at once and raise wider worries about the safety of everyday systems.

Test what you remember

1. What did the hacking attack do to supermarket fridges and freezers?

- (A) It made them colder than usual
- (B) It raised their temperatures
- (C) It turned them into ovens for cooking
- (D) It made them run faster

2. Which Swedish grocers were hit in the attack?

- (A) Delhaize and Ikea
- (B) ICA and Coop
- (C) Coop and Ikea
- (D) Ahold and Colruyt

3. At what time did the attack occur at the ICA store in Stockholm, according to Engla Ingwall?

- (A) At 6 p.m.
- (B) At noon
- (C) At 2 a.m.
- (D) At midnight

4. What happened in the similar attack in France last month?

- (A) Hackers seized control of cooling units at hundreds of supermarkets
- (B) Hackers stole money from supermarket tills
- (C) Hackers closed all French supermarkets for a week
- (D) Hackers changed supermarket prices

5. Has anyone claimed responsibility for either attack?

- (A) No one has claimed responsibility
- (B) Yes, a group in Belgium
- (C) Yes, Moscow claimed responsibility
- (D) Yes, a group in Sweden

6. What did Katrien Eggers say about IT systems and AI?

- (A) AI can now be used to exploit weaknesses in IT systems
- (B) Only old IT systems are vulnerable
- (C) AI has stopped all cyberattacks
- (D) All IT systems are perfectly safe

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. European authorities: Concerned about hybrid threats to infrastructure amid growing security tensions.

2. Moscow: Has repeatedly denied involvement in sabotage or hybrid warfare operations.

3. Katrien Eggers, spokesperson for Belgium's Centre for Cybersecurity: Concerned about the growing number of incidents, in part due to AI, and says all IT systems are potentially vulnerable.

4. ICA spokesperson: Said the company was aware that a limited number of stores were affected overnight.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):